NewsBank inc.

Sonoma State president accused of 'insubordination' for brokering deal with campus protesters

May 16, 2024 | San Francisco Chronicle: Web Edition Articles (CA)
Author: Jordan Parker | Section: News | 759 Words
OpenURL Link

Sonoma State University President Mike Lee was placed on administrative leave one day after he announced the university had reached an agreement with campus pro-Palestinian protesters on divestment from Israel, which Cal State University officials said was "insubordination."

In a statement Wednesday, CSU Chancellor Mildred Garcia said she and the board of trustees were reviewing the situation and announced Dr. Nathan Evans, CSU's Deputy Vice Chancellor for Academic and Student Affairs and Chief Academic Officer, would serve as the university's president effective immediately.

"On Tuesday evening, Sonoma State University President Mike Lee sent a campus wide message concerning an agreement with campus protesters," said Garcia. "That message was sent without the appropriate approvals."

In a second email Wednesday evening, Lee issued an apology and affirmed that he acted alone, without approval from Garcia or other CSU leaders.

"In my attempt to find agreement with one group of students, I marginalized other members of our student population and community," said Lee. "I realize the harm that this has caused, and I take full ownership of it. I deeply regret the unintended consequences of my actions."

Lee added that he would work with Chancellor Garcia's Office to "determine next steps." CSU officials did not indicate how long Lee's leave would last or whether he would return to his role.

The original email sent by Lee detailing the agreement with Sonoma State's chapter of Students for Justice in Palestine was posted on the group's Instagram page and Sonoma State's website. Lee told the campus community that the university would review its investments and disclose information about them and said the university would not participate in study abroad programs, faculty exchanges or collaborations that "are sponsored by, or represent, the Israeli state academic and research institutions."

Lee also said that the university would begin offering a Palestine studies curriculum beginning in the fall. In addition, Lee said the university would create an advisory council for Students for Justice in Palestine so the group could hold university leaders accountable for honoring the agreement.

The fate of the agreement between Lee and the protesters remained unclear Thursday.

Similar agreements have been reached between protesters and university administrators at San Francisco State University and Sacramento State University in exchange for protesters to disband their encampments. Pro-Palestinian protesters at UC Berkeley also disbanded their encampment this week after administrators offered a set of concessions, but stopped short of committing to divestment.

The agreement sparked outcry from prominent members of the Jewish community, including California Sen. Scott Wiener, D-San Francisco.

"Yesterday the President of Sonoma State University aligned the campus with BDS, a movement whose goal is the destruction of Israel, home to (7 million) Jews," Wiener said Wednesday on social media. "Several other UC & CSU campuses are doing this more subtly. Sonoma State simply said the quiet part out loud. The mask is off."

Wiener and Assembly member Jesse Gabriel later released a statement commending Garcia for placing Lee on

leave, saying "his endorsement of an academic boycott was totally unacceptable and evidence that former President Lee is unfit to lead one of our great state institutions."

The agreement between Lee and the protesters came nearly three weeks after the group set up the "SSU Gaza Solidarity Encampment" on Person Lawn on the Rohnert Park campus. The encampment mirrored similar protests at colleges and universities across the U.S. as Israel continues its military campaign along the Gaza Strip, which has killed at least 35,000 Palestinians, according to United Nations officials.

The war in Gaza began on Oct. 7, when militant group Hamas invaded Israel, killed 1,200 people and took 250 hostages, 100 of whom are still missing.

Lee was named interim president of Sonoma State in August 2022, two months after former President Judy Sakaki resigned amid sexual harassment and retaliation allegations involving her and her husband. In May 2023, the CSU Board of Trustees promoted him to president. Before arriving at Sonoma State, Lee had a 28-year career at Sacramento State University, serving as a professor and administrator.

Garcia expressed concern about the fallout Lee's message would have across the Sonoma State campus.

"Our role as educators is to support and uplift all members of the California State University," said Garcia. "I want to acknowledge how deeply concerned I am about the impact the statement has had on the Sonoma State community, and how challenging and painful it will be for many of our students and community members to see and read. The heart and mission of the CSU is to create an inclusive and welcoming place for everyone we serve, not to marginalize one community over another."

Reach Jordan Parker: jordan.parker@sfchronicle.com

© Copyright 2024 San Francisco Chronicle. All rights reserved.

- **Citation (apa Style)**
  Parker, J. (2024, May 16). Sonoma State president accused of ‘insubordination’ for brokering deal with campus protesters.*San Francisco Chronicle: Web Edition Articles (CA)*. Available from NewsBank: Access World News – Historical and Current: https://infoweb.newsbank.com/apps/news/document-view?p=WORLDNEWS&docref=news/19918B90501BF278.